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Martha Wilfahrt

- ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS Department of Political Science, University of California, Berkeley
Associate Professor, July 2026-present
Assistant Professor, 2018-2026
Department of Political Science, Northwestern University
Visiting Assistant Professor, 2017-18
Mellon Postdoctoral Fellow, 2015-17
- EDUCATION Ph.D, Government, Cornell University, 2015
MA, Political Science, Indiana University, Bloomington, 2008
BA, Geography & Political Science (with distinction), University of Wisconsin, Madison, 2005
- PUBLICATIONS *Book*
2021. *Precolonial Legacies in Postcolonial Politics: Representation and Redistribution in Rural Africa*. Cambridge University Press (Cambridge Series in Comparative Politics)

Winner, Allan Sharlin Memorial Book Award, Social Science History Association (2022); Honorable mention: QMMR Sartori Best Book Award, 2022; Long-Listed for the Luebbert Best Book Award, 2022

Journal articles
Forthcoming. Colonial Legacies, Collective Efficacy, and Rural Development: Evidence from the Togo-Ghana Border (with Natalie Letsa) *Comparative Political Studies*

Forthcoming. Unspoken Hierarchies: The Enduring Effects of Caste Discrimination in Africa (with Leonardo Arriola and Dominika Koter) *Perspectives in Politics*

2026. A Precolonial Paradox: Rethinking Political Centralization and its Legacies. *American Political Science Review* 120(2), pp. 419-438.

2025. Understanding the Sensitivity of Party Identification Questions in Polarized African Contexts (with Justine Davis). *Political Behavior*

2023. “Judge, Landlord, Broker, Watchman: Assessing Variation in Chiefly Duties in the Ghana-Togo Borderlands” (with Natalie Letsa) *Journal of*

Modern African Studies, 61(3), pp. 439-462.

2023. "Enumerator Experiences in Survey Data Collection in Sub-Saharan Africa" (with Justine Davis). *Comparative Political Studies* 57(4), pp. 675-709.

Winner, African Politics Conference Group Best Paper Award

2023. "Demanding Recognition: Citizen Perspectives on Clientelism in Africa" (with Jeffrey Paller & Kathleen Klaus) *African Affairs* 122/487, pp. 185-203.

2022. Citizen Response to Local Service Provision: Emerging Democratic Accountability in Decentralized West Africa? *Electoral Studies* 79.

2021. Improving Open-Source Information on African Politics, One Student at a Time (with Kristin Michelitch) *PS: Politics and Society*.

2020. The Mechanisms of Direct and Indirect Rule: Colonialism and Economic Development in Africa (with Natalie Letsa) *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 15(4), pp. 539-577.

2018. Precolonial Legacies and the Contemporary Politics of Public Goods Provision in Decentralized West Africa. *World Politics* 70(2), pp. 239-74.

2018. The Politics of Local Government Performance: Elite Cohesion and Cross-Village Constraints in Decentralized Senegal. *World Development* 103, pp. 149-61.

Winner, African Politics Conference Group Best Graduate Student Paper Award

2018. Popular Support for Democracy in Autocratic Regimes: A Micro-Level Analysis of Preferences (with Natalie Letsa). *Comparative Politics* 50(2).

WORKING
PAPERS

- The Political Effects of Caste in Senegal (with Leonardo Arriola and Dominika Koter)
Guns, Garrisons, and Growth: Revisiting State Formation in Africa (with Leonardo Arriola, Igor Kolesnikov & Yosef Tadesse)

IN PROGRESS

- Endogenous (Re)Districting? The Politics of Subnational Boundary Creation
Indigenous Slavery and Long-Run Inequality in Africa
The Origins of Opposition Strongholds (with Natalie Letsa)
Book Project: Tropical Subjects: Ethnographies of Experimentation

OTHER WRITING

2022. Studying Precolonial Legacies in the Present: Insights from Fieldwork
Broadstreet Blog.

TALKS & PRESENTATIONS	2026 University of California, Irvine; LSE; APSA (scheduled); University of Michigan (scheduled) 2025 APSA; Princeton University; Cornell University 2024 University of Minnesota 2023 MPSA; APSA; ASA; Michigan State University; MIT 2022 APSA; ASA; University of Oklahoma 2021 APSA; ASA 2020 APSA; ASA 2019 MPSA; ISA; APSA 2018 MPSA; GLD, University of Gothenburg; APSA; ASA 2017 MPSA; MGAPE; Northwestern; APSA; ASA 2016 MPSA; Northwestern; APSA; ASA 2015 MPSA; APSA; ASA 2014 MPSA; APSA; ASA 2013 APSA; ASA
AWARDS & HONORS	Lijphart/Przeworski/Verba Dataset Award, APSA Comparative Politics Section, 2026 African Politics Conference Group Best Paper Award, 2024 Society of Hellman Fellows, Research Grant, 2023-24 Kellogg Fellowship, University of Notre Dame, 2023-24 (declined) Allan Sharlin Memorial Book Award, Social Science History Association (2022) Honorable Mention, Giovanni Sartori Best Book Award, Qualitative and Multi-Method Research Section (2022) Undergraduate Research Assistance Program Grant, Northwestern University AY 2016-17 Janice N. and Milton J. Esman Best Dissertation Prize, Cornell University 2016 African Politics Conference Group Best Graduate Student Paper 2014-15 Seed Grant, Center for the Study of Inequality, Cornell University, Fall 2014 Sage Completion Fellowship, Cornell University, 2014-15 Boren Fellow (Senegal), 2012-13 APSA Africa Workshop Fellow, University of Botswana, Gaborone, Botswana, July 2012 Houston I. Flournoy Graduate Fellowship, Cornell University, Summer 2012 Einaudi Center International Research Travel Grant 2010 (Niger), 2011 (Mali)
TEACHING	African Politics (Undergraduate, Graduate) African Politics through Literature and Film (Undergraduate) Political Economy of the Global South (Undergraduate) The Politics of International Aid (Undergraduate) The Politics of Social Welfare (Undergraduate) Major Themes in Comparative Politics (200A) (Graduate) Research and Writing (290) (Graduate)

SERVICE

UC Berkeley

Graduate Studies Council (2022, 2025-26)
Department citation committee (2019, 2026)
CP Field Exam Chair (2026)
Center for African Studies. Rocca Fellowship Selection Committee (2026)
Regents and Chancellor's Fellowship Interviewer (2023-24, 2026)
Philo Sherman Bennett Prize Committee (2023-26)
Faculty Search Committee (2023)
Graduate admissions (2023-24, 2022-23, 2021-22, 2019-20, 2018-19)
Comparative Politics Colloquium convener (2022-23)
Faculty Co-Organizer, Historical Social Science Workshop (2019-2021)
Field exam committee member (Comparative politics: 2023 (2x), 2019; African politics 2019)
IIS Simpson Research Grant Award Committee Member (2023, 2020)
Florence Mason Palmer Prize Judge (2025)
Center for African Studies, FLAS Selection Committee (2022, 2020)

Discipline

American Political Science Association: QMMR Committee Member-at-large (2024-26), QMMR Best Book Award Committee (2023), QMMR Best Article Award Committee (2021), Co-organizer, Research and Development Group African Politics Conference Group, APSA (2020), APCG Finishing-Up Grant Award Committee (2020), APCG Best Book Award Committee (2017)
Midwest Political Science Association: African Politics Section Chair (2023)
Western Political Science Association: Co-organizer, Non-Democratic Politics Mini-Workshop (2023)
Social Science History Association: Sharlin Best Book Award Committee (2023)
Graduate Applications International Network (GAIN): mentor (2020-21)
Reviewer: African Affairs, American Journal of Political Science, American Political Science Review, British Journal of Political Science, Cambridge University Press, Comparative Politics, Comparative Political Studies, Governance, Journal of Development Studies, Journal of Institutional Economics, Journal of Politics, International Journal of Comparative Sociology, International Studies Quarterly, Nature, Perspectives on Politics, Political Behavior, Social Policy and Administration, Theory and Society, World Politics, World Development
Book Manuscript Workshop discussant: Adrienne LeBas and Jessica Gotlieb, *Can Social Intermediaries Build the State?*, 2025; Dominika Koter, *Ethnicity and Nationalism*, 2023; Maria Nagawa, *Aiding State Fracture*, 2026; Noah Nathan, *The Scarce State*, 2021; Peer Schouten, *Roadblock Politics*, 2019